

Do-it-yourself: Secure your laptop

It's a big bad world

Whether you lug your laptop all over the world, or just from home to work and back, the fear of physical loss of the laptop is ever-present. Not all laptops are stolen and sent to the local chop-shop to be re-sold; smart thieves will target laptops to pick up data that is otherwise inaccessible from workstations behind company firewalls. Third-party software tools that will restrict logins and encrypt drives are your best bet against data thieves.

The Bill Gates' of the world probably have a posse of security men guarding their laptops. There are hardware locks available that will let you secure your laptop as you would your bags on a train. Also, using commonly available tools, you can ensure that even if your laptop's stolen, your data remains safe.

Hardware paranoia

Securing your laptop is best achieved by locking it down... literally! Laptop manufacturers provide a little slot where you can attach a lock. This slot is connected to a steel rod within the chassis; taking apart the rod is as good as breaking the laptop. The slot can be identified by a little lock icon, with the letter 'K' on it. Hardware security devices available in India range from the simple to the sophisticated. At the bottom of the list are ordinary devices that lock into the security slot and have a tough steel cable to wind around a table leg, or some permanent hook-like fixture. This prevents a crook from just picking up your laptop and walking away with it. We looked at a mechanical device that has a combination lock and comes with 1.5 m of tough steel cable around it.

Setting it up is simple: attach the device into the security slot, wind the cable around a table leg—or use the supplied steel hook that can be mounted on a wall—and lock it. This device works great if you tend to be less

mobile. Short of sawing through the thick steel cable, the table leg, or trying to break the code on the combination lock, you can't steal a laptop with this device protecting it.

There are more sophisticated devices available that work with inbuilt motion sensors. We found that Targus's DefCon 1 systems (www.targus.com) allow you to set sensitivity levels on a motion sensing equipped device; one particular model, the PA 400, lets you connect a clip-like device into the security lock, loop a steel cable through it and lock it into the motion sensing device. Shake the laptop, or the motion sensing device, and an ear-splitting alarm sounds.

This should be enough to grab the attention of everyone who isn't already deaf, and also give the potential thief a good scare. You can only turn it off by unlocking the three-digit combination lock and undoing the cable. An even more sophisticated DefCon 1 product, the PA 430B, comes with a motion sensing device, cables, a clip and also a remote control that lets you trigger the alarm by proximity as well as motion detection. Move the tiny remote controller beyond 12m from the laptop and the alarm goes off. You can also trigger the alarm by pressing a button in the remote controller.

This device is ideal for travellers, who can secure their laptops whilst travelling in high-risk public areas such as airports. Neither of these security devices will allow you to access the battery compartment until you unlock the device, so somebody intent on stealing your laptop cannot disable the alarm.

